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Following the Party's Lead

Party Cues, Policy Opinion, and the Power of Partisanship in Three Multiparty Systems

Ted Brader and Joshua A. Tucker

Partisanship has long been considered one of the most important determinants of mass political behavior in democracies. Although scholars provide different explanations for the formation and malleability of partisanship, competing theoretical accounts largely agree that it is a predisposition that heavily influences the short-term choices of voters.¹ In particular, many theories stress the heuristic function of partisanship, that is, its ability to serve as a shortcut by which citizens can make up their minds regarding both how to vote and where to stand on policy issues.² As the study of partisanship has spread along with electoral democracy in recent decades, researchers often measure party identification and incorporate it into models of political behavior in a manner similar, if not always identical, to canonical studies in the United States (U.S.). Scholars also take advantage of the existence of comparable measures across countries, like those available as part of the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES) project, to shed light on how contextual factors shape the formation and relevance of partisanship.³ Still others seek to document and explain the emergence (or not) of party attachments during formative periods in new democracies.⁴

In this push to globalize the study of partisanship, much less attention has been paid to whether the concept means the same thing in different polities. When a citizen in France claims to identify with a political party, is she expressing a similar self-understanding (truly thinking of herself as a partisan) in the same way as a citizen giving the same answer in Germany? This issue of comparable self-conceptions is distinct from (though potentially related to) a second concern about the meaning of partisanship: does the self-professed partisanship of these hypothetical French and German citizens imply similar effects on their opinions and behavior? In this article, we take the second tack and examine the extent to which party identifiers in three multiparty systems take cues from their party when expressing policy opinions.

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Does Partisanship Have Comparable Effects Across Countries?

Larry Bartels has observed that the significance of partisanship depends on both the level of partisanship in the electorate and the extent to which partisanship influences behavior.⁵ Received wisdom suggests that partisanship is more prevalent and has a greater impact on political behavior in older democracies where parties are more established and a weaker effect in newer, less stable party systems.⁶ A look at recent data, however, raises doubts about either the survey measures or the received wisdom. For example, the most recent wave of the CSES indicates that Albania has nearly as many self-proclaimed partisans as the U.S. (74 percent vs. 79 percent), while Slovaks claim stronger party ties than either the Germans or Dutch. If self-reports do accurately convey the prevalence and strength of partisanship, we must completely revise our notions of how fast partisanship develops.⁷ If not, then better ways of assessing the nature of partisanship within and across societies are needed.

These concerns are underscored by a small but persistent set of voices who have long dissented on the portability of partisanship even to other established democracies.⁸ The view of American institutional and cultural exceptionalism—myth to some, gospel to others—fuels doubts about the worldwide relevance of partisanship. Despite increases in available data and the use of sophisticated methods, resolution of this debate has proven elusive because often both sides point to the same evidence as supporting their claims. Those who regard partisanship as comparable across democracies point to the ready adoption of party identities and their potency in predicting votes and political attitudes.⁹ Dissenters from this view argue that the correspondence between vote choice and party identification is so high that the two can scarcely mean something different. Jacques Thomassen and Martin Rosema, for example, recognize that such near-perfect correlations could reflect two opposite states of the world—a world in which partisanship is an all but meaningless restatement of current preferences, and a world in which partisanship is so powerful that it rarely permits deviations.¹⁰ They contend, however, that either way, so long as partisanship is highly correlated with the vote, the concept has little use as a distinct analytical tool (relative to party preference) in voting models. But this argument ignores the many reputed effects of partisanship beyond serving as a default vote choice. These effects include its impact on opinion formation (for example, policy opinions or evaluations of government performance), memory, inferences (for example, who is to blame? what are their motives?), factual perceptions (for example, is the economy getting worse?), and the motivation to take political action.¹¹

One way forward, therefore, is to examine the broader effects of partisanship in other countries. Observational studies in many countries have established strong associations between party position taking and partisan opinion formation.¹² Unfortunately, concerns about endogeneity, that partisanship may both influence and be influenced by issue opinions and evaluations, cannot confidently be resolved by standard survey evidence or even panel studies.¹³ Faced with such concerns, researchers increasingly turn to experiments, which offer the ability to isolate causality with confidence, and thus complement the robust estimation of the strength of associations in the population from

observational studies. However, most prior experiments on the effects of partisanship have been run in the U.S. The largest body of such evidence concerns the impact of party labels or cues as a guide to either opinion formation or candidate preference.¹⁴

Renewed attention to the comparative study of partisan effects can deepen and broaden our understanding of partisanship, while moving past protracted debates over the meaning of correlations by using experiments to isolate what effects, if any, partisanship wields over voters from one polity to the next. If such evidence suggests that partisanship has distinct effects across countries, as some have claimed, then scholars can begin to use the same new data to explain why. In this article, we present results from experiments designed to test whether party identifiers adopt policy preferences to match those of their party. Survey experiments are administered in three countries where, unlike the U.S., multiple parties viably compete for legislative seats on a regular basis. These countries include Great Britain, which has one of the oldest, most stable party systems in the world, and two young postcommunist democracies, Hungary and Poland. Although both are relatively new democracies, they are distinguished by the fact that from the collapse of communism to the time we fielded these experiments, the Hungarian party system had been considerably more stable than the Polish party system.¹⁵

The present study makes several notable contributions. First, we are unaware of any prior studies that experimentally test the impact of partisanship in new democracies generally or in these countries in particular. Thus, for each country, these experiments reveal for the first time whether partisanship induces citizens to follow the lead of their party in forming policy opinions. Second, by conducting original experiments in three multiparty systems, we inject new and more diagnostic evidence into long-running debates about the comparability of partisanship across countries. Third, this constitutes a first step toward explaining how and why the meaning or effectiveness of partisanship varies, if indeed it does, across party systems. Fourth, we extend prior experimental research on party cue effects by adapting tests to reflect more fully a multiparty context.

Consistent with work in the U.S., we find that party cues influence the policy preferences of citizens in Great Britain, Hungary, and Poland. Moreover, these effects are clearer and stronger among party identifiers overall than among others who simply prefer the party. Self-reported identification seems to signal a qualitatively similar form of partisanship in new and old democracies, at least in the sense that partisans often follow their party's lead on matters of policy. However, the results are considerably weaker in Poland. Indeed, the cross-national pattern of results suggests that the distinctive power of partisanship over policy opinions may emerge and strengthen with party system crystallization.

Partisanship, Party Cues, and Policy Opinion

Scholars attribute numerous effects to party identification. Partisanship is thought to influence both electoral choices and policy opinions, to bias perceptions of fact and attributions of responsibility, to motivate selective exposure to information and selective

memory for political details, and to spur greater political involvement. These reputed effects of partisanship are consistent with a variety of theories about the nature and causes of partisanship. Adherents of the so-called “Michigan school,” revisionist “rational choice” models, and “social identity” approaches all express interest in the study of partisanship because of its potentially profound effects on political behavior.¹⁶ The present focus is on the idea that partisanship influences policy preferences. Partisans, it is claimed, adopt or adjust their own policy views to match those of their party.¹⁷ No one suggests that partisanship completely determines policy opinions, only that partisans should display a marked tendency to follow their party’s lead.

The first two hypotheses, therefore, stem from the views that party labels serve as useful heuristics and that partisanship matters for opinion formation, respectively:

H1. When policy positions are linked to a political party, citizens who like (or prefer) that party are more likely to support (and less likely to oppose) that policy position.

H2. Self-identified partisans are especially likely to adjust their policy preferences to fit the positions of their party.

Neither hypothesis is new. Scholars have espoused such views for decades. Research providing unambiguous causal evidence about either hypothesis (or especially both simultaneously), however, has been surprisingly rare. Although one could explore many dimensions of the first hypothesis (for example, reactions to cues from other parties), we focus more heavily on the second hypothesis and its implications for partisanship.

Prior experimental studies on the impact of party cues have focused on one country at a time. The vast majority of those were carried out in the U.S., where researchers typically found moderate to dramatic effects of party cues on evaluations of candidates or incumbents,¹⁸ and on policy opinions.¹⁹ Recent experiments also suggest that party cues can affect policy preferences in Canada, Great Britain, Mexico, and even quasi-democratic Russia.²⁰

Prior studies also have examined whether such effects are conditioned by factors such as issue difficulty, issue salience, amount of policy information available, consistency with party reputation, and an individual’s political sophistication. Most studies, however, simply assume as part of their analysis that party identifiers are the ones who follow the cues. As a result, published results typically have not distinguished the reactions of partisans from the reactions of other citizens in a way that might shed light on the impact of self-identification within or across countries. Research by Jennifer Merolla and colleagues offers an exception.²¹ In Mexico they find limited evidence that party identification matters for cue-taking. In Canada they discover that, while identifiers are more responsive to their party’s cues, they are nearly as apt to move in the opposite direction as to follow their party’s lead. It is possible these findings—by turns, modestly consistent with and contrary to expectations—owe something to Mexico’s young party system and instability in the Canadian party system, respectively.²² Although studies

find mixed evidence as to whether education or political sophistication conditions one's responsiveness to party cues,²³ there has been a broad consensus that young adults have weaker partisanship than more mature citizens.²⁴

Like Merolla and colleagues, our focus is not simply on testing the impact of party cues on policy preferences, but also on ascertaining the implications of self-identified partisanship for such behavior. We extend this research to three new countries: Britain, Hungary, and Poland. In an effort to draw more confident conclusions about the impact of partisanship and party cues among citizens generally, we rely on evidence from samples that are more broadly representative of adult populations.

By considering party systems that differ markedly in maturity and stability, we can also begin to explore whether such distinctions might matter for partisan cue-taking. A full-scale systematic analysis bent on isolating how party system and institutional factors shape the impact of partisanship would require comparable experimental data from dozens of countries; this of course is well beyond the scope of what we can accomplish in the present article. Nonetheless, following the country-specific investigations, we leverage the distinctiveness and similarities across settings to draw preliminary inferences about the relationship between party systems and partisan cue-taking.

Previous scholarship calls attention to at least two distinct sets of expectations for cross-national differences in partisanship. At the broadest level, there are the dueling contentions that partisanship is either a more or less similar political force everywhere, stemming perhaps from the human tendency to form group identities or socially reinforced predispositions from a young age,²⁵ or alternatively a special product of an atypical U.S. political system that finds few parallels elsewhere.²⁶ We refer to these as the *universalist* and *exceptionalist propositions*, respectively.

A second set of expectations focuses less on qualitative differences in the relevance of partisanship and more on quantitative differences in the strength of identification. Philip Converse offered perhaps the most influential argument of this sort. He claimed that party identities "crystallize" and strengthen over long periods of attachment that are made possible when the same parties compete in election after election.²⁷ Thus, in older stable party systems, partisanship is inherited from parents during childhood, crystallizes during political experiences in early adulthood, and strengthens over the life cycle. Volatility in party systems—by disrupting those processes—undercuts the continuity and value of partisanship.²⁸ Studies have tested this hypothesis by measuring self-reported strength of identification. But we are more concerned with the actual strength of partisanship—its consequences—than with its nominal strength. To that end, we extend Converse's crystallization hypothesis to predictions about partisan cue-taking:

H3. The tendency of partisans to adjust their policy preferences to fit with the positions of their party will strengthen with the age and stability of the party system.

With experiments from only three countries, any conclusions in regard to H3 will be necessarily tentative. Nevertheless, given how little we truly know about the effects

of partisanship on opinion formation cross-nationally, any observations that can be made in this regard will represent a significant step forward for the field.

Data

Evidence comes from original survey experiments in three countries. The Center for the Study of Public Opinion (CBOS) conducted face-to-face interviews with a national probability sample of Poland in the summer of 2006. Ipsos-Szonda carried out face-to-face interviews with a metropolitan area probability sample of respondents in Budapest, Hungary, in the summer of 2007. YouGov conducted a survey over the Internet in Great Britain, randomly drawing respondents from a large, opt-in panel weighted to reflect the adult British population. The surveys were completed by 409 respondents in Hungary, 607 respondents in Poland, and 2,301 respondents in Great Britain.²⁹ The battery of policy questions making up the focal experiments in this article appeared at the midway point of the interview. Questions soliciting party preference were asked earlier in the survey. Prior research suggests that most of our questions should not be susceptible to strong mode effects by switching from face-to-face to online interviews.³⁰

Experimental Design and Measurement

In order to test whether party cues influence partisans' policy opinions, we designed two types of experimental manipulations. Each varies the presence of party cues in a simple two-cell design: *treatment* questions feature party cues, *control* questions have no party cues. The manipulation involved inserting either a single party cue (SPC) or multiple party cues (MPC). Each survey contained four SPC and three MPC questions.

The SPC manipulation is simpler. Respondents in both conditions were asked whether they support or oppose a policy proposal (on a five-point scale). In the treatment group, this proposal is attributed to a specific political party. The proposal in the control group is attributed to anonymous "experts" or no attribution is given ("A bill has been proposed...").³¹ The party assigned for the treatment cue matches the respondent's *party preference*, which was ascertained by asking respondents which of the major parties they "like the best." We obtained a party preference for 78 percent of respondents in Hungary, 87 percent in Poland, and 93 percent in Britain. By tying the cues to preferences broadly, we can examine whether cue-taking is equally apparent among anyone who likes a party or is especially prominent among partisan identifiers. Analyses of the SPC experiments, therefore, include only respondents who indicated an explicit party preference.

The design of SPC questions requires that the policy proposals can be plausibly linked to any of the major parties (or at least the endorsement must not be wildly implausible). This typically means avoiding highly salient policies on which major parties have taken clear and well-known positions. Although this requirement rules

out many important issues, the impact of cues is questionable anyway when party-issue associations are strong enough to come to mind automatically for voters.³² Our experiments featured bread-and-butter issues such as new taxes or fees to pay for infrastructure improvements, education reform, drinking age laws, personal data security, and foreign relations. We did not ask identical questions in each country because the relevance of the questions would be altered by shifts in context. Instead, we strove to make the questions fairly comparable in the spread of policy domains, diversity of opinion, and question format. One exception is that all three surveys asked about a vague policy described only as the “Primary Education Restructuring Act.”

Voters may largely look for cues from reliable sources, such as their own party.³³ In many polities, however, voters can be alerted to the rival positions of several parties and, unlike the bipolar environment that prevails in two-party systems, voters cannot always assume that unmentioned parties will take an opposing stance from the position attributed to some particular party. The more complicated MPC questions are therefore designed to reflect a reality in which multiple cues are competing for citizens’ attention from all over the ideological map. These questions ask about a policy issue on which people have staked out a variety of positions or rationales. In the treatment condition, each position is attributed to a major party. In the control group, positions are attributed to vague groups of people or experts (for example, “some experts espouse..., while some prefer...”). Analyses focus on whether partisans are more likely to adopt the position associated with their party in the treatment condition than to adopt that same position in the absence of party cues.

Designing MPC experiments does not require finding a single plausible position for all parties. Instead, they require a constellation of positions that can be attributed to different parties such that the overall pattern is plausible. This allows inclusion of a broader set of issues. MPC questions attribute a position that maps reasonably well onto a party’s ideology or even a position it has explicitly adopted. Thus, they constitute a harder test for observing party cue effects, because party supporters may find it relatively easy even in the control group to identify a position likely to be supported by their party. MPC issues included health care reform, highway tolls, nuclear waste, reform of political institutions, and international partnerships. All three surveys have a question touching on immigration and guest permits for foreign workers.³⁴ Similar to the SPC experiments, analysis of the MPC experiments requires that we exclude respondents who do not provide a party preference.

Respondents were randomly assigned to either the treatment or control group for all seven experiments, so they received party cues for all questions or none. Of course, we could not include cues for every party in each country. There is a trade-off between including more parties (and thus including a few more respondents in the analyses) and complicating the design, length, and plausibility of the questions. Thus we needed to limit the cues to the most important parties in each country. For the countries included in this study, the choice of parties was relatively clear. Our broad definition of “major parties” included six parties in Poland,³⁵ four in Hungary,³⁶ and four in Great Britain.³⁷ In the British case, we included a fourth party that varied by region so as not to exclude

the major Scottish and Welsh national parties. Although there could be advantages to using the same number of parties in all countries, the variation simply reflects real cross-national differences in party systems that may (or may not) affect the impact of partisanship.

Testing H2 requires distinguishing self-identified partisans (labeled “partisans”) from individuals who do not identify as partisans but still like one party better than others at the moment (labeled “nonpartisan supporters”). This distinction underlies the original importance of party identification as a concept.³⁸ Many people may prefer or vote for a party in a given situation, but only some of those people identify consistently as a member or adherent of that party.³⁹ It is the meaningfulness of this distinction across societies that has been subject to debate. This test is far more conservative than simply comparing cue-taking among party supporters to cue-taking among those who lack a preference or dislike the party.

We treat as “partisan” anyone who not only prefers a party, but also claims to identify with the same party in response to two separate questions in the survey.⁴⁰ Reliance on multiple measures helps to isolate those who consistently identify with the same party.⁴¹ Partisans are a much smaller group than the total number of people who prefer a party: 39 percent of Hungarians, 46 percent of Poles, and 56 percent of British respondents. The remaining respondents who express a party preference are labeled “nonpartisan supporters.”

Empirical Results

We present the experimental results from each country and conclude with a tentative assessment of how the results compare across countries. The three countries vary in terms of the age and stability of party systems. Great Britain has the oldest and most stable party system of the three; indeed, its three largest political parties are all over 100 years old.⁴² Of course scholars expect the most critical phases of partisan development to occur in the first generation or two of democracy, a situation that describes many postcommunist countries.⁴³ The Hungarian and Polish party systems are composed largely of parties that came into existence either at the very end of the communist period or during the postcommunist era. The two differ, however, in the age and stability of their party systems. Hungary, at the time of the survey, had arguably the most stable party system in postcommunist East Central Europe, with the same four parties having dominated Hungarian politics at least since the mid-1990s, if not the first election in 1990.⁴⁴ In contrast, Poland’s party system largely imploded in the lead-up to the 2001 parliamentary elections, with a number of important new parties (including the current ruling Civic Platform Party and its primary opposition, the Party of Truth and Justice) emerging at that time.⁴⁵ Quantitative measures such as the average level of electoral volatility also reveal Poland (42 percent average volatility) to have a much less stable party system than Hungary (25 percent average volatility).⁴⁶ Indeed, Poland had been one of the most electorally volatile of the postcommunist countries, while Hungary had been one of the least.⁴⁷

Great Britain Table 1 presents results from the seven experiments in Britain. The figures in each cell represent the average treatment effect. For SPC experiments, the effect is the difference in support for the policy among respondents who did receive a party cue versus those who did not. For MPC experiments, the effect is the difference in the proportion of respondents in the treatment and control groups who picked the position affiliated with their preferred party. Higher values in either experiment indicate movement toward the party's position when party cues are present. The first column of results shows the effects among nonpartisan supporters, while the second column shows the effects among partisans.

Table 1 Effects of Party Cues on Support for Proposed Policies in Great Britain

Type of Cue / Issue	Nonpartisan Supporters	Partisans
SINGLE PARTY CUES		
Lifting EU arms embargo to China	+ 0.10	+ 0.09*
	[.08]	[.06]
	(p = .11)	(p = .08)
Prohibiting storage of electronic data without individual consent	+ 0.06	+ 0.27***
	[.09]	[.07]
	(p = .24)	(p < .01)
Raising the drinking age for wine and spirits to 21	+ 0.04	+ 0.23***
	[.10]	[.08]
	(p = .35)	(p < .01)
"Primary Education Restructuring Act"	+ 0.13***	+ 0.18***
	[.05]	[.04]
	(p < .01)	(p < .01)
MULTIPLE PARTY CUES		
Imposing tolls on roads	+ 0.02	+ 0.07***
	[.03]	[.03]
	(p = .22)	(p < .01)
Use of nuclear power	+ 0.02	+ 0.04**
	[.03]	[.02]
	(p = .27)	(p = .045)
Establishing limits on immigration	+ 0.03*	+ 0.03
	[.03]	[.03]
	(p = .09)	(p = .12)
N	768	1282

Note: Cell entries are the effect of the party cue (i.e., Support in Treatment – Support in Control for SPC; Proportion Matching Party's Position in Treatment – Proportion Match Party's Position in Control for MPC). Standard errors are in [brackets]; p-values for one-tailed t-tests are in (parentheses).

*p < .10; **p < .05, ***p < .01.

Beginning with the SPC experiments, we find statistically significant effects across all four issues among British partisans, with an average shift of 0.19 units, which amounts to 5 percent of the length of the scale. The largest effects occur for the issue of electronic data privacy, where a shift of 0.27 units or 7 percent of the scale length ($p < .01$) is observed, and for raising the drinking age for wine and spirits (0.23 units or 6 percent of the scale, $p < .01$). Similarly, two of the three MPC experiments produced statistically significant effects in the predicted direction among partisans. Partisans receiving cues were seven percentage points more likely to share the same position as their party on imposing new tolls on roads ($p < .01$) and four percentage points more likely to share their party's position on immigration ($p < .05$). In the final MPC experiment on immigration, respondents receiving party cues were three percentage points more likely to share their party's position, although our confidence in this effect falls slightly below conventional thresholds of statistical significance ($p = .12$).⁴⁸

The British experiments clearly demonstrate that party cues can induce partisans to follow their party's lead in expressing opinions on matters of public policy. What then of the distinction between partisans and nonpartisans? Is this party cue effect uniform across partisans and nonpartisans, or is it more pronounced among partisans, as the second hypothesis predicts?

Table 1 suggests clear support for this hypothesis as well, although not uniformly across every experiment. Specifically, for three of the seven experiments, the effects look fairly similar across nonpartisan supporters and partisans with similar magnitudes of effects and p -values. This includes questions concerning the lifting of an EU arms embargo against China, support for the vaguely titled "Primary Education Restructuring Act," and establishing limits on immigration. For the remaining four issues, however, the effects are larger for partisans than nonpartisans. Consider especially the SPC experiments regarding the storage of electronic data and raising the drinking age, where the effects are more than four and five times as large, respectively. Moreover, while the effects are in the correctly predicted direction for nonpartisans for these four issues, in all four cases the standard errors exceed the size of the predicted effect. In contrast, we find statistically significant effects at a $p < .01$ level for three of these four issues among partisans; for the remaining issue (nuclear power), we still have confidence that the effect is larger in the treatment group at a level of $p < .05$ among partisans.

Taken together, the British experiments demonstrate that party cues influence policy opinion in a long-established, multiparty democracy other than the U.S., and that party identifiers more consistently follow their party's lead than nonpartisan supporters. The next task then is to examine the impact of party cues in a relatively young, albeit fairly stable, multiparty system.

Hungary As the results in Table 2 show, the Hungarian experiments also turn up empirical support for the hypotheses. In the SPC experiments, we observe more favorable opinions toward the proposed policy in three of the four treatment conditions among partisans; two of these three effects are statistically significant. The absolute size of the two largest effects are even (slightly) larger than any effect observed in the

British surveys. When party cues are present, Hungarian partisans become more supportive of an expansion in Internet access in return for higher computer fees (0.29 units or 7 percent of the length of the scale, $p = .09$) and of the “Primary Education Restructuring Act” (0.34 units or 9 percent of the scale, $p = .03$). Party cues caused mean support for increasing defense spending to rise 0.14 units among partisans, though the standard error is too large to generate confidence in this effect.

Table 2 Effects of Party Cues on Support for Proposed Policies in Hungary

Type of Cue / Issue	Nonpartisan Supporters	Partisans
<i>SINGLE PARTY CUES</i>		
Expand Internet Access & Computer Fee Hike	– 0.07 [.21] ($p = .64$)	+ 0.29* [.22] ($p = .09$)
Metro Improvement & Fare Hike	+ 0.17 [.19] ($p = .18$)	+ 0.00 [.21] ($p = .49$)
Increase Defense Spending to NATO Levels	+ 0.01 [.21] ($p = .49$)	+ 0.14 [.20] ($p = .24$)
“Primary Education Restructuring Act”	+ 0.01 [.20] ($p = .49$)	+ 0.34** [.18] ($p = .03$)
<i>MULTIPLE PARTY CUES</i>		
Reform of Healthcare Services	– 0.10 [.08] ($p = .89$)	– 0.05 [.08] ($p = .74$)
Support Russian Pipeline Project Relative to EU Pipeline Project	+ 0.05 [.08] ($p = .28$)	– 0.02 [.08] ($p = .58$)
Increase Number of Guest Workers	– 0.02 [.07] ($p = .62$)	+ 0.16** [.07] ($p = .01$)
<i>N</i>	143	160

Note: Cell entries are the effect of the party cue (i.e., Support in Treatment – Support in Control for SPC; Proportion Matching Party’s Position in Treatment – Proportion Match Party’s Position in Control for MPC). Standard errors are in [brackets]; p -values for one-tailed t -tests are in (parentheses).

* $p < .10$; ** $p < .05$; *** $p < .01$.

Turning to the MPC experiments, we find a statistically significant effect in the predicted direction in only one of three experiments among partisans. However, the magnitude of this effect—a sixteen percentage point increase in the proportion of Hungarian

partisans matching their party's position on guest workers when a party cue is present—is by far the largest found in any MPC experiment across three countries. The other two MPC experiments, however, even fail to produce shifts of opinion in the correct direction.⁴⁹

When comparing partisans to nonpartisan supporters (H2) in Hungary, the effects of party cues appear more pronounced among the former. Unlike the findings for partisans, there is not a single statistically significant effect of party cues among nonpartisan supporters across seven tests. Indeed, three of the opinion shifts among nonpartisans are in the wrong direction, and two more are in the expected direction but barely greater than zero. Results of the remaining two tests, however, suggest some caution against overestimating the distinctiveness of partisans in Hungary. For the SPC Metro experiment, though results for both groups were statistically insignificant, there is a modest opinion shift in favor of the proposed fare hike among nonpartisan supporters compared to no shift among partisans. Similarly, a larger share of nonpartisans matched their party's position on a proposed Russian pipeline when party cues were available, but partisans were less likely to match their party's position (though again neither effect is statistically significant).

All told then, in Hungary, we find several instances in which party cues influence the policy opinions of partisans, as well as an overall pattern of evidence suggesting that the tendency to follow the party's lead is clearer among partisans than nonpartisan supporters (consistent with H2). We now turn to the final set of experiments to a new postcommunist democracy where the party system had been much less stable.

Poland As shown in Table 3, the Polish results look quite different from those in the other two countries. Among partisans, only one of the four SPC experiments produces an opinion shift in the correct direction that even approaches statistical significance: Polish partisans are more likely to support an increase in auto fees to fund road improvements when party cues are present ($p = .11$). Two of the SPC tests produce statistically insignificant effects in the wrong direction. Similarly, party cues have only one statistically significant effect on partisans' opinions in the MPC experiments. In this case, partisans are eight percentage points more likely to match their party's position on proposed reforms to legislative elections when receiving a party cue.

Thus, there is only weak evidence for the impact of party cues on policy opinion formation among Polish partisans. In addition, there is no empirical support for the prediction that cue-taking is stronger among partisans than nonpartisan supporters (H2) in Poland. In particular, the SPC experiment on providing financial support to opposition movements in Belarus produced a pattern unseen in any of the twenty other experimental tests across the three surveys: party cues had a strongly positive and significant effect among nonpartisans (0.25 units or 6 percent of the scale, $p = .02$), but a sizable negative (albeit insignificant) effect among partisans. Party cues also had a strongly positive and significant impact on opinion among nonpartisans on the issue of road improvements (0.39 units or 10 percent of the scale length, $p < .01$).

While the Polish experiments indicate that party cues can on occasion influence the policy opinions of partisans, their impact appears considerably weaker here than

Table 3 Effects of Party Cues on Support for Proposed Policies in Poland

Type of Cue / Issue	Nonpartisan Supporters	Partisans
<i>SINGLE PARTY CUES</i>		
Road Improvements & Auto Fee Hike	+ 0.39***	+ 0.17
	[.14]	[.14]
	(p < .01)	(p = .11)
Joint Military Exercises with Russia	- 0.11	- 0.11
	[.14]	[.12]
	(p = .77)	(p = .81)
Funding for Opposition Forces in Belarus	+ 0.25**	- 0.13
	[.13]	[.13]
	(p = .02)	(p = .83)
“Primary Education Restructuring Act”	- 0.03	+ 0.06
	[.08]	[.09]
	(p = .66)	(p = .25)
<i>MULTIPLE PARTY CUES</i>		
High School Exchange (w/Germany)	- 0.04	- 0.00
	[.03]	[.03]
	(p = .89)	(p = .53)
Reduce Number of Legislators & Switch to Single Member District Legislative Voting	- 0.01	+ 0.08**
	[.05]	[.05]
	(p = .57)	(p = .05)
Increase Number of Guest Workers	- 0.01	+ 0.04
	[.05]	[.05]
	(p = .56)	(p = .20)
N	225	282

Note: Cell entries are the effect of the party cue (i.e., Support in Treatment – Support in Control for SPC; Proportion Matching Party’s Position in Treatment – Proportion Match Party’s Position in Control for MPC). Standard errors are in [brackets]; p-values for one-tailed t-tests are in (parentheses).

*p < .10; **p < .05, ***p < .01.

it did in Hungary or Great Britain. Moreover, unlike these other two countries, the second hypothesis fares poorly in Poland: there is nothing to suggest that Polish party identifiers are more likely to follow their party’s lead than nonpartisan supporters.

Revisiting the Cross-National Comparability of Partisanship

One major goal of this article is to move forward the long-running debate about whether partisanship matters outside of the U.S., or, put differently, whether the classic conception of party identification (as a powerful predisposition) is largely a feature of

American exceptionalism or a more universal phenomenon. On the basis of twenty-one new experimental tests in three countries, we find substantial evidence that party cues influence policy preferences, especially among partisans. Party cues did not lead opinion in every instance, but of course that was never the expectation. Still, among partisans, ten tests produced significant positive effects and six more produced positive effects that fell short of significance.

Moreover, in the vast majority of these cases, particularly in Great Britain and Hungary, the impact among partisans was not only clearer but also notably larger than the impact among nonpartisan supporters. It is also worth remembering that this comparison is a conservative one: the impact of party identification above and beyond the impact of simply preferring a party over others at the moment. Had we designed experiments to compare cue-taking among partisans to cue-taking among those truly indifferent about parties, “independents,” or even those who identify with rival parties, it is likely that the difference in reactions would have been much starker.

Although our findings cast further doubt on the exceptionalist proposition, the pattern of findings is hardly identical across the three countries in this study. Scholars have long suggested that partisanship becomes stronger as the party system remains stable and ages, but this claim has nearly always been tested with self-reported identity strength rather than more objective assessments of the power of partisanship. Our three cases include one venerable, stable party system (Great Britain), one relatively new and stable party system (Hungary), and one new and fairly unstable party system (Poland). With this in mind, the results of the experiments are almost perfectly in line with expectations laid out in the third hypothesis. Partisan cue-taking and the distinctive impact of party identification are most clearly evident in Britain. Both are apparent, but less consistently so, in Hungary. Finally, in Poland, partisan cue-taking is weak and the behavior of party identifiers is not distinct from other nonpartisan supporters at all.

Another observation stands out from comparison of these cases. The Hungarian results, especially for the SPC experiments, more closely resemble the British results than the Polish results. This suggests that the effects of partisanship—at least on policy opinions—strengthen fairly quickly in the first couple of decades of democracy rather than strengthening slowly over generations. The findings also underscore the importance of party system stability for the development of partisanship in new democracies.⁵⁰

Conclusion

We had three primary goals in this article. First, we sought to address enduring questions about whether partisanship means anything outside of the U.S., and, in particular, in multiparty systems. Second, we wanted to take first steps toward explaining more precisely how and why the impact of partisanship varies, if indeed it does, across countries. And third, we aimed to improve knowledge about the impact of party cues on policy opinion formation by expanding experimental tests to multiparty systems. All three efforts have been fruitful.

Both the SPC and MPC experiments returned numerous instances of party cues affecting policy opinions of partisans in countries outside of the U.S., and they revealed important distinctions in the effects of party cues on partisans and nonpartisans outside of the U.S. Taken together, these two findings provide considerable support for the universalist proposition at the expense of the exceptionalist proposition. For at least the sort of cue-taking effects examined in this study, claims that the effects of partisanship stop at the borders of the U.S. ring hollow. Evidence from three new countries may not end debate completely, but it should raise serious doubts about the exceptionalist position.

What about the final hypothesis, that partisan effects should be stronger and clearer in older, more stable party systems? Here we must approach our findings carefully. On the one hand, we have conducted experiments in only three countries, far too few to be able to generalize much beyond these cases for reasons we have already noted. On the other hand, the results—at least for these three cases—came out exactly as we would have expected based on party system maturity and stability. The effects of partisanship were strongest in Great Britain, weakest in Poland, and fell somewhere in between in Hungary.

By observing the portability of partisanship and its effects across societies, we also take the first important steps toward a clearer understanding of how political context shapes the effectiveness of partisanship, as well as shedding light on how partisanship functions in these particular polities. A single article covering three countries can hardly make a definitive statement on system-level explanations. But while we have taken only modest steps toward that much larger goal, this article presents more experimental tests across more countries than any previous study of party cues or partisanship. The result is a comparative experimental study that significantly increases the scope of what is known about the causal power of partisanship. We find broad evidence that party cues can affect policy preferences, and such effects appear to become especially prominent among self-identified partisans as party systems stabilize and endure. From this perspective, partisanship seems to take on some similar functions across countries, functions that seem to develop after only a few rounds of competitive elections among the same parties. Further research is needed not only to validate this claim among a larger set of countries, but also to investigate other proposed effects of partisanship. The present study suggests that students of political behavior have much to gain from collecting comparable experimental data across a much broader range of political systems.

NOTES

1. Christopher Achen, "Parental Socialization and Rational Party Identification," *Political Behavior*, 24 (June 2002): 151–70; Angus Campbell, Philip Converse, Warren Miller, and Donald Stokes, *The American Voter* (John Wiley & Sons, 1960); Philip Converse, "Of Time and Partisan Stability," *Comparative Political Studies*, 2 (April 1969): 139–71; Morris P. Fiorina, *Retrospective Voting in American National Elections* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 1981); Charles Franklin and John Jackson, "The Dynamics of Party Identification," *American Political Science Review*, 77 (December 1983): 957–73; Donald P. Green, Bradley Palmquist, and Eric Schickler, *Partisan Hearts and Minds* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2002).

2. Larry Bartels, "Beyond the Running Tally: Partisan Bias in Political Perceptions," *Political Behavior*, 24 (June 2002): 117–50; W. Phillips Shively, "The Development of Party Identification among Adults: Exploration of a Functional Model," *American Political Science Review*, 73 (December 1979a): 1039–54.
3. John Huber, Georgia Kernell, and Eduardo Leoni, "Institutional Context, Cognitive Resources, and Party Attachments across Democracies," *Political Analysis*, 13 (July 2005): 365–86.
4. Ted Brader and Joshua A. Tucker, "The Emergence of Mass Partisanship in Russia," *American Journal of Political Science*, 45 (January 2001): 69–83. Ted Brader and Joshua Tucker, "Pathways to Partisanship: Evidence from Russia," *Post-Soviet Affairs*, 24 (July–September 2008): 263–300; David Samuels, "Sources of Mass Partisanship in Brazil," *Latin American Politics and Society*, 48 (July 2006): 1–27.
5. Larry Bartels, "Partisanship and Voting Behavior, 1952–1996," *American Journal of Political Science*, 44 (January 2000): 35–50.
6. Converse, 1969; Russell J. Dalton, *Citizen Politics: Public Opinion and Political Parties in Advanced Industrial Democracies*, 4th ed. (New York: CQ Press, 2006).
7. We use the terms partisanship, party identification, and party attachments interchangeably.
8. Ian Budge, Ivor Crewe, and Dennis Farlie, eds., *Party Identification and Beyond* (London: John Wiley & Sons, 1976); Richard Johnston, "Party Identification: Unmoved Mover or Sum of Preferences?" *Annual Review of Political Science*, 9 (June 2006): 329–51; Jacques Thomassen and Martin Rosema, "Party Identification and the Vote: A Comparative Study" (Paper presented at the annual meeting of the International Society of Political Psychology in Barcelona, July 2006).
9. Dalton, 2006.
10. Thomassen and Rosema.
11. Bartels, 2002; Geoffrey Cohen, "Party Over Policy: The Dominating Impact of Group Influence on Political Beliefs," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 85 (November 2003): 808–22; Drew Westen, Pavel S. Blagov, Keith Harenski, Clint Kilts, and Stephan Hamann, "Neural Bases of Motivated Reasoning: An fMRI study of Emotional Constraints on Partisan Political Judgment in the 2004 U.S. Presidential Election," *Journal of Cognitive Neuroscience*, 18 (October 2006): 1974–58.
12. Harold D. Clarke, Marianne C. Stewart, and Paul Whiteley, "Tory Trends: Party Identification and the Dynamics of Conservative Support since 1992," *British Journal of Political Science*, 27 (April 1997): 299–331; Sara Binzer Hobolt, "Taking Cues on Europe: Voter Competence and Party Endorsements in Referendums on European Integration," *European Journal of Political Research*, 46 (February 2007): 151–82; William G. Jacoby, "The Impact of Party Identification on Issue Attitudes," *American Journal of Political Science*, 32 (August 1988): 643–61.
13. Pamela Johnston Conover and Stanley Feldman, "Candidate Perception in an Ambiguous World: Campaign, Cues, and Inference Processes," *American Journal of Political Science*, 33 (November 1989): 912–40. See also Bartels, 2002; Franklin and Jackson.
14. Kevin Arceneaux, "Can Partisan Cues Diminish Democratic Accountability?" *Political Behavior*, 30 (June 2008): 139–61; Travis G. Coan, Jennifer L. Merolla, Laura B. Stephenson, and Elizabeth Zechmeister, "It's Not Easy Being Green: Minor Party Labels as Heuristic Aids," *Political Psychology*, 29 (May 2008): 389–405; James N. Druckman, "Using Credible Advice to Overcome Framing Effects," *Journal of Law, Economics, and Organization*, 17 (April 2001): 62–82; Cindy Kam, "Who Ties the Party Line? Cues, Values, and Individual Differences," *Political Behavior*, 27 (June 2005): 163–82; Wendy Rahn, "The Role of Partisan Stereotypes in Information Processing about Political Candidates," *American Journal of Political Science*, 37 (May 1993): 472–96; Cohen.
15. The Hungarian experiments occurred well before the Hungarian parliamentary elections of 2010, which may signal important shifts in the Hungarian party system.
16. For Michigan school, see Campbell et al.; for rational revisionist, see Achen; Fiorina; for social identity, see Green et al. These theoretical approaches may suggest some differences, such as the precise degree of individual-level partisan stability and corresponding nature of partisan dynamics [e.g., see Harold D. Clarke and Allan L. McCutcheon, "The Dynamics of Party Identification Reconsidered," *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 73 (September 2009): 704–28], but they make similar claims about many facets of partisanship.
17. Warren Miller, and J. Merrill Shanks, *The New American Voter* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1996); John Zaller, *The Nature and Origins of Mass Opinion* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1992).
18. Arceneaux; Neil Malhotra and Alexander Kuo, "Attributing Blame: The Public's Response to Hurricane Katrina," *The Journal of Politics*, 70 (January 2008): 120–13; Rahn; Thomas Rudolph, "Triangulating Political Responsibility: The Motivated Formation of Responsibility Judgments," *Political Psychology*, 27 (February 2006): 99–122.

19. Coan et al.; Cohen; Druckman; Kam.
20. Jennifer L. Merolla, Laura B. Stephenson, and Elizabeth J. Zechmeister, "Can Canadians Take a Hint? The (In)Effectiveness of Party Labels as Information Shortcuts in Canada," *Canadian Journal of Political Science*, 41 (September 2008): 673–96. David Sanders, Harold D. Clarke, Marianne C. Stewart, and Paul Whiteley, "The Endogeneity of Preferences in Spatial Models: Evidence from the 2005 British Election Study," *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion, and Parties*, 18 (October 2008): 413–31; Jennifer Merolla, Laura Stephenson, and Elizabeth Zechmeister, "La Aplicación de los Métodos Experimentales en el Estudio de los Atajos Informativos en México," *Política y Gobierno*, 14 (September 2007): 117–42; Ted Brader and Joshua A. Tucker, "What's Left Behind When the Party's Over: Survey Experiments on the Effects of Partisan Cues in Putin's Russia," *Politics and Policy*, 37 (August 2009): 843–68.
21. Merolla et al. 2007, 2008.
22. In both cases, study participants were college students, so it is possible their behavior does not well reflect that of other voters.
23. Some studies have found larger cue effects among subjects who possess less political knowledge (e.g., Kam) or education (e.g., Malhotra and Kuo, 2008).
24. Achen; Converse, 1969; Franklin and Jackson.
25. Campbell et al.; Green et al.
26. Berglund et al. 2005; Johnston; Thomassen and Rosema.
27. Converse, 1969; Russell J. Dalton and Steven Weldon, "Partisanship and Party System Institutionalization," *Party Politics*, 13 (March 2007): 179–96.
28. Dalton. 2006.
29. Overall response rates were 48.9 percent for the Hungarian survey and 50.8 percent for the Polish survey, based on the Response Rate 1 definition stipulated by the American Association for Public Opinion Research (AAPOR). The cooperation rates were 70.4 percent and 74.7 percent, respectively (AAPOR Cooperation Rate 1). The British Internet survey had a completion rate of 38.4 percent.
30. On mode effects, see Sanders et al.; Neil Malhotra and Jon Krosnick, "The Effect of Survey Mode and Sampling on Inferences about Political Attitudes and Behavior: Comparing the 2000 and 2004 ANES to Internet Surveys with Nonprobability Samples," *Political Analysis*, 15 (Summer 2007): 286–323. Variable sample sizes may raise concerns that any differences in the presence or number of "significant" findings across settings is merely an artifact of statistical power. Fortunately, our results do not at all appear to be driven by variation in the number of participants across countries; see note 50 on this point as well. We would also have preferred to collect a national sample in Hungary, rather than just the Budapest metropolitan area. The experimental design insulates us from many concerns about the comparability of results due to the sampling differences, because respondents were randomly assigned to the treatment and control group. Nonetheless, certain characteristics associated with living in the capital city (e.g., exposure to politics, higher education) might affect responsiveness to partisan cues or susceptibility to opinion change. Although evidence to date is mixed, some studies suggest that such sample differences might lead one to understate the average impact of party cues in Hungary (e.g., see Kam; Malhotra and Kuo, 2008).
31. For complete question wording and the distributions of responses, see the appendix which appears in the online version of this article at www.ingentaconnect.com/content/cuny/cp.
32. If positions are clear and well known, then any influence on partisans' preferences has likely occurred prior to the experiment. See Arceneaux for evidence that party cues diverging from well-known positions often fail or backfire.
33. Druckman.
34. All of the policy proposals for both the SPC and MPC experiments were created by the authors for the purpose of the study. The positions attributed to parties were based on thorough research of party positions from primary sources (e.g., platforms, party websites), secondary sources (e.g., descriptions of parties' positions by academics and journalists), and consultation with survey organizations and country experts. All respondents were debriefed following the interview regarding the constructed nature of these proposals.
35. Citizen's Platform, Law and Justice, Samoobrona RP, the Democratic Left Alliance, the League of Polish Families, and the Polish Peasant's Party.
36. The Hungarian Socialist Party, FIDESZ-Hungarian Civic Party, the Alliance of Free Democrats, and the Hungarian Democratic Forum.
37. Labor, Conservative, and the Liberal Democrats were included for all respondents. Plaid Cymru was included in the surveys administered in Wales and the Scottish Nationalist Party was included in surveys administered in Scotland. To mimic this idea of a nationalist party in England, we included the UK Independence Party as the fourth party in England.

38. Campbell et al.
39. One could think of this distinction as akin to the difference between someone who, on rare occasion, attends an athletic event and roots for the home team and a die-hard “fan” who is emotionally invested in every outcome and brooks no disparagement from outsiders.
40. One self-identification measure is the fairly common “closeness” (“Do you usually think of yourself as close to any particular political party...”) battery used in the CSES as well as other surveys. The second measure is a battery developed by Timothy Colton for countries with multiple parties where there may not be language of identification: “Please tell me, is there any one among the present parties, movements, and associations about which you would say, ‘This is my party, my movement, my association?’” [See Timothy Colton, *Transitional Citizens* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2000).] Both questions have follow-up prompts designed to give the respondent a second chance to indicate a partisan leaning. Analyses include respondents who name a party in response to either the initial question or the follow-up.
41. We do so because of concern about the use of single, self-reported measures to identify partisans, especially in new democracies. Relying on multiple indicators helps alleviate these concerns. See Brader and Tucker, 2001; Green et al.
42. There is a well-established literature on partisan dealignment in older democracies [e.g., Russell Dalton and Martin Wattenberg, *Parties without Partisans: Political Change in Advanced Industrial Democracies* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2000)] and in Britain in particular [e.g., Ivor Crew, Bo Sarlvik, and James Alt, “Partisan Dealignment in Britain 1964–1974,” *British Journal of Political Science*, 7 (April 1977): 129–90]. However, we expect the effects of partisanship even in a dealigning Britain to be stronger than in new democracies. An alternative hypothesis (to H3) might state that, due to dealignment, we should not see significant differences between the effects of partisanship in Britain compared to Hungary and Poland. As we demonstrate, though, such a hypothesis would find no support in our data.
43. Converse, 1969.
44. We use the term “party system” in its most general sense: a way of summarizing the relationships among political parties in the political system of a country; see Alan Ware, *Political Parties and Party Systems* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996). Party systems may be described by a number of attributes, including the number of competitive parties or “size” of the system, its degree of fragmentation, its age or stability, the social or issue cleavages that define the bases of party support. By a more “stable” party system, we refer to one in which the primary parties have been viably contesting for votes for a longer period of time. While the current *electoral* systems in Poland and Hungary emerged in 1989–1990, the *parties* currently making up the Hungarian party system were older on average than those in Poland at the times of the surveys, and elections in Hungary featured less electoral volatility.
45. For more detail, see Radoslaw Markowski and Joshua Tucker, “Euroskepticism and the Emergence of Political Parties in Poland,” *Party Politics*, 16 (July 2010): 532–48.
46. We measure electoral volatility using the standard Pedersen Index of volatility, or $\text{Volatility} = (\sum_{i=1}^n |p_{it} - p_{i,t+1}|)/2$ where n is number of parties and p_i represents the percentage of votes received by that party in time periods t and $t + 1$. As volatility requires a *pair* of elections, the measures are calculated starting with the second election since the collapse of communism in 1989 through the summer of 2009. Data are drawn from Eleanor Neff Powell and Joshua A. Tucker, “New Approaches to Electoral Volatility: Evidence from Postcommunist Countries,” Paper presented at the annual meeting of the American Political Science Association in Toronto, September, 2009, available at SSRN: <http://ssrn.com/abstract=1449112>.
47. Powell and Tucker, 2009. To be clear, we are referring to *electoral* volatility and *party system* stability; in the development of other democratic institutions, Poland has exhibited much more stability.
48. Note that, due to numerical rounding, p-values in the table may differ even when the ratio between coefficients and standard errors appears similar.
49. Note that the oil pipeline issue is structured a bit differently than the rest of the MPC experiments (see the online appendices in this article at www.ingentaconnect.com/content/cuny/cp).
50. As is evident from the tables, the number of subjects differs across categories. This is due to the fact that there are more partisans than nonpartisans in all three surveys and due to differences in funding for sample sizes across countries. If statistically significant effects emerged only in the groups with the largest number of subjects, there could be reason for concern. However, the results are reassuring in this regard. The nonpartisan British category has more subjects than any of the Polish or Hungarian categories, and yet we have multiple examples here where results are statistically insignificant. In addition, the fewest statistically significant effects among partisans are in the Polish experiments, yet it is the Hungarian experiments that have fewest number of subjects.